Northwind Health Insurance - Claims Handling Guide

Product: Individual Health Cover, Silver Plan (NH-2026-01). Guide version 3.2. Effective 1 January 2026.

This internal guide explains how claims handlers apply the policy terms in policy document NH-2026-01: pre-authorisation, limits and excess, documents, settlement, declined claims, fraud checks and appeals. Where this guide and the policy document differ, the policy document applies.

This document is a fictional sample created for testing purposes only.

Section 1: Claims Overview and Pre-authorisation

All claims are assessed against the policy terms, the underwriting decision recorded at inception and the waiting periods.

Pre-authorisation is required before treatment starts for all inpatient treatment, day-case surgery, and MRI, CT and PET scans. A claim without pre-authorisation may be reduced by 25% or declined, unless treatment was an emergency.

Pre-authorisation requests are answered within 2 working days. An authorisation is valid for 90 days.

Emergency treatment does not need pre-authorisation, but the claims team must be told within 48 hours of admission.

Section 2: Claim Limits and Excess

Limits apply per policy year, which runs from the effective date of the policy.

Benefit	Annual limit	Excess
Inpatient hospital treatment	GBP 100,000	GBP 150 per claim
Day-case surgery	GBP 15,000	GBP 150 per claim
Specialist consultations	Included in outpatient limit	GBP 25 per visit
Outpatient benefits (total)	GBP 1,500	None
Mental health outpatient	20 sessions	GBP 25 per session
Diagnostic scans (MRI, CT, PET)	Included in outpatient limit	GBP 50 per scan

The excess is deducted from the amount we pay, once per claim, not once per invoice. Limits reset at each renewal.

Section 3: Documents and Time Limits

A claim is complete when all of the following have been received:

(a) The claim form, signed by the insured person.

(b) The itemised invoice from the provider.

(c) The referral letter from a registered physician.

(d) The pre-authorisation number, where one was required.

(e) A medical report, if the claims handler requests one.

Claims must be submitted within 6 months of the treatment date. A claim submitted later is declined unless the delay was outside the insured person's control, such as a hospital stay.

We aim to pay a complete and valid claim within 10 working days of receiving the last document.

Section 4: Reasons a Claim May Be Declined

A claim is declined when:

(a) The treatment is for a condition covered by an exclusion recorded at underwriting.

(b) The treatment falls within a waiting period: 14 days for inpatient treatment, 30 days for specialist outpatient consultations, 6 months for dental and optical benefits.

(c) The treatment is a general exclusion, such as cosmetic surgery, fertility treatment, pregnancy and childbirth (other than complications), or experimental treatment.

(d) The treatment took place outside the United Kingdom and was not emergency treatment during travel of less than 30 days.

(e) The claim is submitted after the 6-month time limit without a valid reason.

(f) A material fact was not disclosed at application, which may also void the policy.

A declined claim must be explained in writing, quoting the policy wording that applies.

Section 5: Claims Fraud and Investigation

Claims handlers must refer a claim to the counter-fraud team before payment when any of the following is found:

(a) Treatment dates that overlap or do not match the provider's records.

(b) Invoices from a provider that cannot be verified.

(c) A claim for a condition that was declared as an exclusion, or that appears to pre-date the policy and was not declared.

(d) Three or more claims of GBP 1,000 or more in a single policy year.

While a claim is under investigation, the insured person is told within 5 working days that a review is under way. A confirmed fraudulent claim leads to the claim being declined and may lead to the policy being cancelled.

Section 6: Complaints and Appeals on Claims

An insured person who disagrees with a claim decision may appeal in writing within 90 days of the decision, including any new evidence such as a specialist letter.

An appeal is reviewed by a senior claims handler who was not involved in the first decision, and is answered within 15 working days.

If the person is still not satisfied with the final response, they may refer the complaint to the Financial Ombudsman Service.